Plan 7 · Kinnaur in Winter (by toy train)

Toy train up to Shimla, then the Sutlej road into Kinnaur: Narkanda–Hatu, Sarahan's Bhimakali temple, Sangla and Kamru fort, Kalpa facing Kinnaur Kailash, Nako's frozen lake, then NYE back on Shimla's Ridge and the toy train down. 6 people

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → Delhi day → Kalka Mail → **toy train** → Shimla → Narkanda 1N → Sarahan 1N → Sangla 1N → Kalpa 2N (Nako day) → Shimla 1N (NYE) → **toy train** down → Kalka Mail → Delhi → Hyderabad
Why Kinnaur	The most dramatic snow scenery you can reach by road in late December without a flight. The Shimla–Reckong Peo road (NH-5) is kept open in winter. Very few tourists. It's the lower half of the Spiti winter road, which itself doesn't fit 10 days.
Snow chances	Very high: Kalpa, Nako, Sangla. High: Hatu, Sarahan. Chitkul is usually cut off after mid-December
Crowd level	Very low (except Shimla Ridge on NYE)
Difficulty	Easy walking, but long mountain drives (5–8 h/day), black ice and −10 to −15 °C nights. Needs an experienced Kinnaur driver with chains
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹21.4k shoestring · ≈ ₹28.1k recommended**

Road reality in late December

Kalpa and Reckong Peo are reliable because BRO/PWD clear them. **Sangla can close after heavy snow; Chitkul usually stays closed after mid-December** until March. Black ice on the Sarahan, Sangla, Kalpa and Nako roads.

Keep 31 Dec flexible: if snow blocks the way down, stay in Narkanda/Rampur and come to Shimla on 1 Jan morning (the toy train down is at 17:40).

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi on 24 Dec: board in Hyderabad, Kazipet, Warangal or Vijayawada

Train	Where you board (time)	Reaches Delhi	Runs	Fare / person (SL · 3A)	Use it for
12723 Telangana SF Exp	**Hyderabad Deccan 06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25 · Kazipet 08:03/08:05	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Default.** Cheapest, boards in the city. Delhi day + night train/bus onward
12621 Tamil Nadu SF Exp	Vijayawada 03:50–04:05 · Warangal 06:50/06:52 · **Kazipet 06:55**	New Delhi **06:30** (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950 (from Kazipet)	**Fast option.** Catches the 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → Shimla same evening
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 07:00/07:10 · Kazipet ~08:50	H. Nizamuddin 05:30	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 (meals incl.)	Fast and comfortable but ~2× the 3A fare
12625 Kerala SF Exp	Vijayawada ~10:10–10:55 · Warangal ~13:30 · **Kazipet 13:45**	New Delhi 13:30	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Backup if 12723 is full (leave Hyderabad by 09:30 by bus)

Getting to Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada with 6 people: Kazipet and Warangal are ~140 km (2.5–3 h). TGSRTC buses run through the night from JBS/Uppal to Hanamkonda (≈ ₹200–300), or an Innova one-way ≈ ₹4,000–5,000 (≈ ₹750 pp). Vijayawada is ~275 km (5–6 h). Only worth it if Hyderabad quota is full, because you'd need an overnight bus on 23 Dec.

12723 halts in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (~18 halts, ~1,680 km). Confirmed: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30.

Waitlisted? Check every station and halt this way

1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC / ConfirmTkt / ixigo, search 24 Dec: HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, **KZJ→NDLS, WL→NDLS, BZA→NDLS** (Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada have their own quotas). Note AVAILABLE / RAC / WL for every train above.

2. Every halt. If HYB→Delhi is WL, search the same train from HYB to each later halt (Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur). A shorter ticket can be AVAILABLE when the full one is WL. Ride to Agra, then any Agra→Delhi train or bus (2–3.5 h).

3. Book from the origin. For trains starting elsewhere (22691 from Bengaluru, 12621 from Chennai, 12625 from Thiruvananthapuram), search origin→Delhi and set **Boarding Point** = Secunderabad / Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada. You pay the full-route fare but get the origin's quota.

4. Split it. HYB→Nagpur + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains a day). Keep 2–3 h between them.

5. Tatkal on 23 Dec (AC 10:00, SL 11:00), 2 PNRs of 3 people each. Premium Tatkal costs more but confirms more often.

6. Tick Vikalp + auto-upgrade and only hold WL if it is under ~WL 20 (3A) / WL 40 (SL) this far out.

6 people = 1 PNR in general quota (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

Delhi → Kalka → Shimla by toy train (connections and buffers)

If you arrive in Delhi on…	Delhi → Kalka	Kalka → Shimla (toy train)	In Shimla	Buffers	Train cost / person
12723 Telangana · New Delhi ~07:40 (25 Dec)	**12311 Netaji (Kalka Mail)**, Old Delhi ~21:10 → Kalka ~03:00–04:40 (SL)	**52453 Kalka–Shimla Exp** ~06:00–06:20 (2S ≈ ₹65) or 52451 Shivalik Deluxe ~05:20–05:45 (CC ≈ ₹510)	~10:30–11:50 on 26 Dec	~13 h in Delhi = a sightseeing day; 1–3 h in Kalka waiting room	**≈ ₹265** (SL ≈ ₹200 + 2S ₹65)
12621 Tamil Nadu · New Delhi 06:30	**12011 Kalka Shatabdi**, New Delhi 07:40 → Kalka 11:40–11:45 (CC ≈ ₹885 incl. meal)	**52455 Himalayan Queen** 11:55–12:10 → ~17:20 (CC ≈ ₹265; 2S cheaper)	~17:20 on **25 Dec**	70 min at New Delhi (fog risk), ~25 min at Kalka (timed connection)	≈ ₹1,150
22691 Rajdhani · Nizamuddin 05:30	Same 12011 Shatabdi (Nizamuddin → New Delhi 15–20 min by metro/cab)	52455 Himalayan Queen	~17:20 on 25 Dec	~2 h at Delhi	≈ ₹1,150
12625 Kerala · New Delhi 13:30	12311 Kalka Mail ~21:10 (or 12005 Kalka Shatabdi 17:15 → 21:15 + a night in Kalka)	52453 / 52451 next morning	~11:00 on 26 Dec	~7.5 h Delhi	≈ ₹265

Late-December fog regularly delays trains from the south by 1–4 h. If the fast option misses the 07:40 Shatabdi, fall back to the Kalka Mail at night: you lose half a day, not the trip. Book the Shatabdi only after checking the Tamil Nadu Express running status the evening before (Tatkal opens 10:00 on 24 Dec).

Kalka–Shimla toy train timetable (both directions)

Direction	Train	Departs	Arrives	Classes & approx fare	Notes
Kalka → Shimla	52457 Kalka–Shimla (earliest)	~03:30	~08:55	2S / FC	Listed by some 2026 guides. Verify; may be seasonal
Kalka → Shimla	72451 Rail Motor Car	05:10–05:25	~09:30	≈ ₹320	Glass-roof railcar, 14–18 seats; runs only with enough bookings
Kalka → Shimla	52451 Shivalik Deluxe	05:20–05:45	~10:05–10:40	CC ≈ ₹510 (breakfast incl.)	Fastest regular train
Kalka → Shimla	**52453 Kalka-Shimla Exp**	06:00–06:20	~11:05–11:50	**2S ≈ ₹65**; FC higher	Cheapest reserved seat
Kalka → Shimla	52455 Himalayan Queen	11:55–12:10	~17:20	2S cheap · CC ≈ ₹265 · FC ≈ ₹475	Connects with the 12011 Shatabdi
Shimla → Kalka	52456 Himalayan Queen	10:40	16:10	As above	Connects to evening Delhi trains
Shimla → Kalka	52458 Passenger	14:20–14:25	~20:10	2S / FC	
Shimla → Kalka	52452 Shivalik Deluxe	17:40–17:50	~22:25–22:45	CC ≈ ₹510	Connects to the overnight Kalka Mail to Delhi
Shimla → Kalka	52454 Kalka–Shimla Exp	18:25–18:30	~23:20–23:30	2S ≈ ₹65	

Timings differ by 10–25 min between sources (travelcoffee 2026, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, totaltraininfo). Confirm on IRCTC/NTES when you book. Book toy-train seats on IRCTC as soon as the main train is confirmed; 25–26 Dec sells out. Sit on the right side going up for the valley views. The Him Darshan Vistadome (≈ ₹630) runs on some dates.

Coming down on 1 Jan

Step	Train	Time	Buffer
Shimla → Kalka	**52452 Shivalik Deluxe** (or 52454 Express, 2S ≈ ₹65)	~17:40 → ~22:25–22:45 (52454: ~18:30 → ~23:30)	—
Kalka → Delhi	**12312 Netaji (Kalka Mail)**, SL	Kalka around midnight (verify) → Old Delhi ~06:00 on 2 Jan	~1–1.5 h at Kalka
Delhi → Hyderabad	**12724 Telangana Exp** from New Delhi	16:00 → ~17:10 on 3 Jan	~10 h Delhi day

If the Kalka Mail timing doesn't line up, take the 10:40 Himalayan Queen down (Kalka 16:10) and an evening train or bus from Kalka/Chandigarh to Delhi.

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025–26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → Delhi

• **06:00 12723 Telangana Express**.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi day → 21:10 Kalka Mail

• Old Delhi circuit, India Gate, Sacred Heart. Kalka Mail from Old Delhi (SL).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700 + ₹200 train

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Toy train → Shimla → Narkanda

• Kalka toy train (05:20–06:20) → Shimla ~10:30–11:50 → Innova picks you up at Shimla station → lunch on the Ridge → **Narkanda** (2 h).

Stay: Airbnb Narkanda | **Day spend (per person):** ₹65–510 toy train + ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Hatu Peak → Rampur → Sarahan

• Sunrise at **Hatu Peak** → down to the Sutlej at **Rampur** (Padam Palace) → **Sarahan** (2,165 m): **Bhimakali temple** (Indo-Tibetan wooden architecture), Shrikhand Mahadev views.

Stay: Sarahan (HPTDC Shrikhand / homestay) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Sarahan → Karcham → Sangla (Chitkul if open)

• Karcham dam → Baspa valley → **Sangla**: **Kamru fort** village, Bering Nag temple, apple orchards in snow.

• **Chitkul** (last village before Tibet) only if the road is open; otherwise **Rakchham**.

Stay: Sangla homestay | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Sangla → Kalpa

• **Kalpa** (2,960 m): Kinnaur Kailash at sunrise and sunset, **Chini village** and Narayan-Nagini temple, **Roghi village** and the Suicide Point cliff road. Reckong Peo market for supplies.

Stay: Kalpa homestay | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Khab confluence · Nako frozen lake (day trip)

• Leave 07:00: Spillow → **Khab** (Sutlej–Spiti confluence) → **Nako** (3,660 m): village and the lake, usually frozen in winter. Back to Kalpa by dark (~8–9 h round trip). Skip it if there's fresh snow.

Stay: Kalpa homestay | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Kalpa → Shimla · NYE on the Ridge

• Long drive down (~220 km, 8–9 h, leave 07:00). Evening: Shimla Winter Carnival on the Ridge, Mall Road for New Year's Eve.

Stay: Airbnb Shimla | **Day spend (per person):** ₹1,000 Innova share + ₹1,000 NYE food

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Shimla day → toy train down → Kalka Mail

• Jakhoo ropeway, Christ Church, Viceregal Lodge, Lakkar Bazaar, ice-skating rink if open. **17:40 Shivalik Deluxe** (or 18:30 Express) down to Kalka.

• Kalka Mail overnight to Old Delhi.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300–700 + ₹200–600 train + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → Hyderabad

• Old Delhi ~06:00 → Humayun's Tomb / Lodhi Garden → **16:00 12724**.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹400 + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

- Hyderabad ~17:10.

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
1 (26 Dec)	Narkanda	**Hatu Peak View 3BR Villa | Homeyhuts**: 4.8★ (10)	**Pahadi House** / **Wild Orchard** homestay rooms	₹5,000–8,000	₹850–1,350
1 (27 Dec)	Sarahan	Not on Airbnb: **HPTDC Hotel Shrikhand** or temple-side homestays	Homestay rooms ₹1,000–1,500	₹3,500–6,000	₹600–1,000
1 (28 Dec)	Sangla	Not on Airbnb: Baspa-side homestays (Booking.com / phone)	Homestay rooms ₹1,000–1,500	₹3,500–6,000	₹600–1,000
2 (29–30 Dec)	Kalpa	Few Airbnbs: Kinnaur Kailash-view homestays · **HPTDC Kinner Kailash**	Homestays ₹1,000–1,800 per room	₹4,000–7,000	₹650–1,150
1 (31 Dec)	Shimla	**VICTORIAN VILLAS 3BHK** (4.51★, 106, 6 guests)	**Jasm Homes 3BHK**	₹7,000–10,000	₹1,150–1,650

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Bike rentals

Not in winter Kinnaur. Black ice, −10 °C wind and 200 km days. The Innova with a local driver and snow chains is the safe (and, for 6, cheaper) option.

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Narkanda / Hatu stalls	Snow suits, gumboots	₹300–500
Kalpa / Reckong Peo market (buy)	Woollen socks, caps, Kinnauri shawls/caps	Buy
Indiahikes rentals (online)	Down jacket (−10 °C), shoes	₹55–150/day

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi (12723)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Delhi day (25 Dec)	₹400	₹500	
12311 Kalka Mail, Old Delhi → Kalka	₹200	₹200	SL (short overnight run; 3A ≈ +₹400)
Toy train Kalka → Shimla	₹65	₹65	52453 2S
Innova 26–31 Dec (6 days, Kinnaur winter rates, driver nights, tolls)	₹6,000	₹6,300	≈ ₹36–38k ÷ 6
Shimla local on 1 Jan + toy train Shimla → Kalka	₹300	₹400	52454 2S (52452 Shivalik Deluxe CC ≈ ₹510)
Kalka → Delhi overnight (12312 Kalka Mail)	₹200	₹200	SL (short overnight run; 3A ≈ +₹400)
Delhi day (2 Jan)	₹300	₹400	
Train Delhi → Hyderabad (12724)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Stays: Narkanda, Sarahan, Sangla, Kalpa ×2, Shimla (NYE)	₹5,400	₹7,800	Homestays / HPTDC / Airbnb ÷ 6
Food	₹5,000	₹5,500	
Entries, misc	₹300	₹500	
Winter gear rentals	₹800	₹1,000	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹21,365**	**₹28,065**	**Fits ₹25–30k on SL. The Innova is the main cost; winter Kinnaur drivers charge a little more.**

Bookings to do now

- 12724 (2 Jan) → 12723 (24 Dec) → 12311 Kalka Mail (25 Dec) → toy train up (26 Dec) → toy train down + 12312 (1 Jan).
- An Innova from a Shimla/Rampur operator who does winter Kinnaur (ask about chains and 4x4 backup).
- Shimla NYE Airbnb (31 Dec) first; Kinnaur homestays by phone a week ahead.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.

- Altitude: Nako is 3,660 m, so walk slowly and stay hydrated. Carry dry fruits and a thermos in the car.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

- Kinnaur winter roads (Kalpa open; Sangla may close; Chitkul shut after mid-Dec): vargiskhan Kinnaur winter guides, discoverwithdheeraj, raachotrekkers, travelcoffee
- Toy train both directions: travelcoffee, Shimla Tourism, exploreindia, sunrisevilla timetable, totaltraininfo; Kalka Mail: Cleartrip, RailMitra, indiantrain
- Spiti winter (why not a full plan): discoverwithdheeraj, treksandtrails, Spiti Holiday Adventure, travelshoebum
- Innova rates: Rajputana Cabs, Triveni Cabs; Airbnb Narkanda/Shimla listings via search (Nov 2026)